The *S* stands for '*Stay* close to the cross'. Religion is, naturally, a personal issue but, for me, feeling close to and mindful of God enables me to function as a human being. I started to subscribe to a monthly booklet called *Every Day with Jesus*, and got into the habit of reading the entry every single morning.

REPS has remained with me all these years, at the forefront of my mind as much when things are going well as when they're not. It's neither a secret code nor a magic formula, but it helps.

On another occasion, early in 2008, the chairman of my support team asked me to meet him at the Wanderers Stadium. It was a normal weekday in Johannesburg and, with people going about their business on Corlett Drive, he suggested we meet each other at the main gate, walk straight in to the stand and then sit quietly in the back row.

The famous Bullring was completely empty and completely silent.

'Imagine this place is full of South Africans,' he said. 'Imagine they're standing and cheering, imagine they are waving national flags and hugging each other, imagine they are smiling and laughing, imagine that – for just a moment – amid all the uncertainty and excitement of change, amid the anxiety caused by rising crime and a falling rand, they are actually feeling great about their country and optimistic about the future.

'And imagine that it is you standing out there in the middle, in the middle of all this joy and celebration, humbly raising your bat in recognition of the applause, batting with all the talent you have been given, completely maximising your ability to play this game, entertaining and thrilling the crowd, helping the Proteas to another victory.

'That is the high road, AB. That's the opportunity before you, and you can take it by being prepared to make all the sacrifices, by being totally committed. It's not an easy road. In fact, it's a very difficult road.

'You are 24 years old but, unfortunately, you can't behave like any other 24-year-old. Most people your age are starting out in their professional careers and they will probably reach their peak in around 20 years